Twelve Things to Notice and Write Down When Your Father's Care Isn't Working

What to pay attention to this week in the tasks, your sister's week and the family's conversations. Notes only, no verdicts.

Everyone in the family has a view about what is wrong with your father's care. What almost nobody has is a week of notes. This guide names twelve everyday things worth noticing and, for each, what to write down.

Notice and record, with the day and who saw or said it. Don't interpret, and don't keep score on anyone. What a note means for your father's health is a question for his doctor or nurse, and what it means for his care is for the people who assess him. The things to notice follow what the National Institute on Aging, the Family Caregiver Alliance and MedlinePlus tell families and caregivers to pay attention to; the wording about what to write down is ours.

The tasks

1 Appointments and rides [1]

NOTICE Which appointments were kept, which were missed or moved, and who knew about each one.

WRITE DOWN The date, what happened, and who was expecting to take him.

2 Medications in the house [2]

NOTICE Whether he has the medications he needs, and whether he is taking them regularly.

WRITE DOWN What you saw, with the day. Change nothing; questions go to the pharmacist or the doctor's office.

3 Bathing and clothes [2]

NOTICE Whether he is bathing regularly and dressed for the weather on the days you see him.

WRITE DOWN What you saw and when, and who helps him, if anyone does.

4 The house and the kitchen [2]

NOTICE Whether the home is fairly clean and clear of clutter, and how much food is in the house.

WRITE DOWN What you saw, plainly, and who usually does the shopping and the cleaning.

5 Mail, bills and paperwork [1]

NOTICE Unopened mail, a bill nobody has dealt with, a form waiting for a signature.

WRITE DOWN What is waiting, since when, and who usually handles it.

Your sister's week

6 What she does [3]

NOTICE Each thing she handles for your father in a week, including the phone calls, the driving and the waiting.

WRITE DOWN The task and the day, as she tells it. Ask her; don't estimate for her.

7 What she says can't continue [4]

NOTICE Her answer when you ask what cannot go on the way it is, and what would help most.

WRITE DOWN Her words, as close as you can get them, and the date you asked.

8 Sleep and time of her own [4] [5]

NOTICE What she tells you about her sleep, and about having time to eat properly, exercise or see other people.

WRITE DOWN What she said, in her words. Don't add what you think it means.

9 Offers of help [4]

NOTICE What happens when someone offers a hand: whether the answer is “Thanks, but I'm fine,” and what she asks for, if anything.

WRITE DOWN What was offered, what she said, and anything specific she has asked for.

The family's conversations

10 Where a call leaves the subject [3]

NOTICE The moment a conversation turns from a task to a person: “You always,” “You never,” or a word like selfish or bossy.

WRITE DOWN The topic you were on when it turned. Not who started it.

11 What your father says [2] [3]

NOTICE What he says he needs and wants when someone asks him directly, and whether he tells each of you the same thing.

WRITE DOWN His words, with the day and who he was talking to. Keep them separate from what the family wants for him.

12 Different accounts and different views [3]

NOTICE Where two of you describe the same event differently, or see differently whether he should move or have more help.

WRITE DOWN Both versions side by side, with who said what and the reason each gives. Don't pick a winner.

When to call instead of write

Notes are for things the family can talk about later. If something you notice leaves you concerned about your father's physical or mental health, the National Institute on Aging says to suggest a visit to a health care provider: call his doctor's office, say what you saw, and let them tell you what happens next. If your sister brings up her own health, that is for her own doctor, and the National Institute on Aging suggests caregivers tell their doctor that they are one. In an emergency, call emergency services.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any of these mean, how anyone is doing, or what care your father needs. It doesn't measure your sister. The notes give the family something specific to talk about, and they go to the people who assess him.

Ready for the next step?

You know what to notice this week and how to write it down. The care interview gives those notes somewhere to go: it walks you through your father's situation area by area, including the parts of the week nobody has been watching, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. National Institute on Aging, Getting Started With Caregiving
2. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving with Your Siblings
4. National Institute on Aging, Taking Care of Yourself: Tips for Caregivers
5. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine), Caregiver Health